a major cause of biodiversity loss worldwide. It affects the growth of phytoplanktons and finally changing the aquatic ecosystem.

It also decreases the oxygen content of the waterbodies which leads to eutrophication. It poses a threat to human health because it creates a breeding habitat for disease causing mosquitoes (particularly *Anopheles*) and snails with its free floating dense roots and semi submerged leaves. It also blocks sunlight entering deep and the waterways hampering agriculture, fisheries, recreation and hydropower.

Lantana camara

Identified as one of the worst invasive species by Global Invasive Species Database. It is also an invasive weed native to South America introduced as ornamental plant. It occupies a widely adaptable range of habitats.



Figure 8.6: *Lantana camara*

This species is spread by birds It exerts allelopathic effect, which reduces the growth of surrounding plants by inhibiting germination and root elongation. Root removal and bio-control are the best methods to control. Now tribes are trained to use the stem as fibre for making household materials like baskets, furniture and even cots.

Parthenium hysterophorus

Parthenium hysterophorus native to South America introduced accidently into many regions of the world along with imported food grains. It is a harmful weed in the forest which suppresses the growth of native species and reduces the availability of fodder for animals



Figure 8.7: *Parthenium hysterophorus*

It infests pastures and farmland causing often loss of yield. The plant produces allelopathic chemicals that suppress crop and native plants and its pollen causes allergic rhinitis and asthma, dermatitis in humanbeing.

Prosopis juliflora

Prosopis juliflora is an invasive species native to Mexico and South America. It was first introduced in Gujarat to counter desertification and later on in Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu as a source of firewood. It is an aggressive coloniser and as a consequence the habitats are rapidly covered by this species. Its invasion reduced the cover of native medicinal herbaceous species. It is used to arrest wind erosion and stabilize sand dunes on coastal and desert areas. It can absorb hazardous chemicals from soil and it is the main source of charcoal.



Figure 8.8: *Prosopis juliflora*

8.7 Conservation

India due to its topography, geology and climate patterns has diverse life forms. Now this huge diversity is under threat due to many environmental issues for this conservation becomes an important tool by which we can reduce many species getting lost from our native land. By employing conservation management strategies like germplasm conservation, in situ, ex-situ, in-vitro methods, the endemic as well as threatened species can be protected

In-situ conservation

It means conservation and management of genetic resources in their natural habitats. Here the plant or animal species are protected within the existing habitat. Forest trees, medicinal and aromatic plants under threat are conserved by this method. This is carried out by the

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